

Insights from *Tiny Habits* by BJ Fogg, PhD

The universal formula for human behavior is: **B = MAP** (a **behavior** happens when **motivation**, **ability**, and a **prompt** converge at the same moment).

If you're developing a new habit (like reading a book every night before bed), you will perform the habit if your motivation (desire to read) matches the ability required to read (access to a book and time needed to hit your daily reading goal) the moment you receive a prompt to read (get a reminder on your phone or see a book on your nightstand).

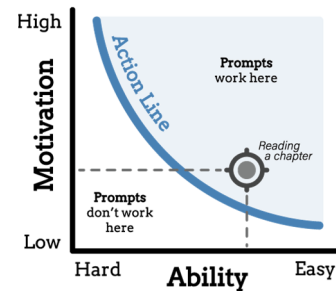
You can hack the universal behavior model and consistently perform a desired habit (like reading before bed) by using the parts of BJ Fogg's "Tiny Habits Method."

Part #1: Shrink the Behavior

Fogg provides the following chart (from BehaviorModel.org) to explain the relationship between motivation and ability:

If a task is hard (high ability required), then you need high levels of motivation to rise above the "action line" and complete the task. Rescuing your child from a burning building is a hard thing to do, but high motivation rises you above the action line and compels you to enter the burning building.

If a task is easy (low ability required), you only need a little motivation to rise above the "action line" and complete the task. Brushing your teeth is easy to do. It doesn't matter if you're exhausted when you get the prompt to do it; you do it anyway.



BJ Fogg suggests shrinking every new habit to the tiniest possible version, so you don't need to rely on motivation. You can find the tiniest version of your desired habit by either reducing the quantity or doing just the first step. For example:

- The tiniest version of a sixty-minute meditation practice is a one-breath-meditation.
- The tiniest version of a daily planning routine is writing down one to-do item on an index card and putting the index card in your pocket.

Your goal is to find a behavior that you can easily do in thirty seconds or less.

Part 2: Identify an Action Prompt

There are three types of habit prompts (habit reminders):

1. External/context prompts: cues from your environment like post-it notes, phone notifications, and alarms.
2. Internal prompts (also known as personal prompts): thoughts and sensations that remind you to act, like a grumbling stomach.
3. Action prompts: the completion of one behavior reminds you to start the next behavior. Loading the dishwasher can be a prompt to clean the kitchen countertops.

External and internal prompts are distracting and de-motivating. If you use an alarm to prompt your new habit, you'll need to stop what you're doing and pivot to your new habit. But if you use an action prompt, momentum will carry you from one behavior to the next, and you'll need less motivation to start your new habit. There are many action prompts you can use to perform a thirty second habit. For example, you can execute a one-breath-meditation habit after checking your phone, picking up the TV remote, turning off a light, or washing your hands.

After BJ Fogg walks through the door from work, he gets out his gym clothes. After he sits down on the train, he opens up his sketchbook. After he puts his head on his pillow, he thinks of one good thing that happened during the day.

Complete Part 2 of the *Tiny Habit Method* by completing the sentence: After I ____, I will ____.



Part 3: Grow Your Behavior with Some Shine

"Shine" is a term BJ Fogg created to explain the feeling you get after an accomplishment. The closest thing in English language is authentic pride. **"You know this feeling already: You feel Shine when you ace an exam. You feel Shine when you give a great presentation and people clap at the end. You feel Shine when you smell something delicious that you cooked for the first time."** – BJ Fogg

You **MUST** generate the feeling of Shine after you execute your tiny habit if you want to sustain and grow your habit. It may sound ridiculous to feel pride and success after doing one pushup or flossing one tooth but learning to celebrate tiny wins is the most critical component of habit development (based on BJ Fogg's extensive habit develop research).

When you give yourself a steady dose of *Shine* after doing the tiniest version of a habit, your motivation will steadily grow. When your motivation increases, you move higher up the "action line" and can tackle harder habits. Soon your one-breath-meditation turns into a 5-minute meditation and eventually a 60-minute meditation you look forward to every day.

"When you feel successful at something, even if it's tiny, your confidence grows quickly, and your motivation increases to do that habit again and perform related behaviors. I call this success momentum. Surprisingly enough, this gets created by the frequency of your successes, not by the size... You that you can resist learning to celebrate (small completions), but be aware that you're choosing not to be as good as you could be at creating habits. For most people, the effort of learning to celebrate is a small price to pay for becoming a Habit Ninja." – BJ Fogg